Inner Circle

User purposes and prototype planning

Team discussion draft | Business Fundamentals | October 13, 2026

A professional relationship manager that helps users organize, explore, maintain, and expand their networks through connected graph and list views.

High-level purposes

High-level purpose	Proposed features	Example scenario
Organize and remember my network	Add/edit/remove contacts; store personal details, shared experiences, and conversation notes; categorize contacts	Record someone met at a conference and preserve what you discussed
Find the right people	Search; combine filters; temporarily hide irrelevant contacts; save filtered views	Find alumni working in a relevant industry without browsing the entire network
Understand my network	Group contacts by chosen categories; compare groups; visualize geographic distribution; explore connection and career timelines	Understand which industries, locations, or communities your network covers
Maintain and strengthen relationships	Follow-up reminders; interaction history; relationship-strength indicator; identify relationships needing attention	Review important connections you have not contacted recently and decide whom to reconnect with
Expand my network intentionally	Explore second-degree and more distant connections; inspect mutual connections and introduction paths; combine these with filters	Find people in a target organization whom an existing contact could introduce you to

Shared interface concept: Switch between graph and list views while retaining the same search, filters, and selected contacts. Category, geographic, and timeline views offer additional ways to explore the network.

Low-level purposes

Detailed scenario inventory | 1-6 of 16

Proposed scenarios, not validated requirements. Alternatives describe plausible use of spreadsheet + LinkedIn; they are not claims about Devon's actual behavior.

Purpose	Action within the app	Features	Alternatives	Low-level example of purpose
Find someone relevant to a current goal	Combine criteria, review matching contacts, and save a shortlist	Filters across company, role, expertise, location, and personal notes; saved lists	Search LinkedIn and cross-check spreadsheet notes	Find contacts working in climate policy in Washington, DC
Recover a person whose name I forgot	Search remembered context and recognize the matching person	Search across notes, events, organizations; photos where available	Search spreadsheet text, old messages, and LinkedIn profiles	Who was the Duke alum I met who worked on housing policy?
Prepare for a conversation	Open one person's history and review relevant details	Contact page; dated notes; interaction timeline; open commitments	Read spreadsheet notes and previous LinkedIn messages	Before an informational interview, recall their advice and what you promised to do
Preserve useful context with little effort	Add a brief note immediately after meeting someone	Quick capture; automatic date; optional voice input; contact matching	Open the spreadsheet and enter a note, or postpone it	Met Maya at the policy panel; she studies transit; send her the report
Keep a specific promise	Record an action with a due date and mark it complete	Person-linked tasks; reminders; completed/pending status	Add a spreadsheet column or use a separate calendar/task app	Send an article tomorrow after promising it during a conversation
Maintain selected relationships	Choose whom to stay in touch with and review a manageable follow-up queue	User-selected priorities; adjustable reminders; notes attached; snooze	Manually review contact dates and maintain calendar reminders	Spend 15 minutes Friday following up with three chosen contacts

Low-level purposes

Detailed scenario inventory | 7-11 of 16

Purpose	Action within the app	Features	Alternatives	Low-level example of purpose
Reconnect for a concrete request	Identify suitable contacts and review the relationship before reaching out	Goal-based shortlist; relationship history; user-assessed familiarity	Recall names, inspect the spreadsheet, and reopen old messages	Reconnect with professors before asking for academic references
Find a meaningful reason to reconnect	Review recorded interests, unresolved topics, or shared experiences	Searchable interests; follow-up topics; previous commitments	Read old notes/messages and think of something relevant	Share a report related to a contact's research rather than sending "just checking in"
Meet people during travel or relocation	Filter by current city, review context, and shortlist people	Location filters; city groups; optional map; location freshness indicator	Filter a city column and manually verify profiles	Before a London trip, identify three contacts to invite for coffee
Focus without deleting dormant contacts	Hide irrelevant contacts from a working view while retaining their records	Saved filters; tags; archive; active/dormant views	Spreadsheet filters, extra tabs, or an "active" column	Show this semester's internship contacts while retaining former coworkers
Follow up after an event	Review people met at that event and identify unfinished next steps	Event tags; date filters; notes; tasks	Record an event column and inspect each row manually	The morning after a career fair, find everyone you promised to message

Low-level purposes

Detailed scenario inventory | 12-16 of 16

Purpose	Action within the app	Features	Alternatives	Low-level example of purpose
Understand whether my network covers a goal	Compare relevant groups and inspect gaps	Multi-label grouping; counts; optional category visualization	Spreadsheet filters/pivot tables plus LinkedIn searches	Notice that you know policy researchers but few implementation practitioners
Give value to someone in my network	Find contacts whose interests match an opportunity or resource	Interest tags; note search; relevant-contact shortlist	Search notes or rely on memory	Find someone interested in an urban-policy fellowship you just discovered
Find an introduction to a new person	Inspect a known intermediary and review the basis for asking	Explicit "introduced by/knows" relationships; focused path view	Inspect available LinkedIn mutual-connection information and ask contacts	Ask a former colleague whether they know a particular policy director
Act on a relevant career change	Review a recorded role change and decide whether to reconnect	Dated employment history; optional verified change alerts	Revisit profiles and manually update spreadsheet rows	Congratulate a former classmate who recently joined a target organization
Start using the product without rebuilding everything	Import existing records, resolve duplicates, and retain an exportable copy	CSV import; field mapping; duplicate review; export	Keep using the existing spreadsheet because migration is too much work	Bring Devon's existing notes into the app without retyping them

Pipeline toward the prototype

Use the purpose tables to agree on scope before moving into workflow, implementation, and prototype design.

1. Decide on user purposes

Decide which user purposes "connections maintenance" is split into.

2. Decide on features

Decide which features would cover the selected user purposes.

3. Decide on the general workflow

Decide on the general workflow through the app.

4. Decide on implementation

Decide on implementation of the app.

5. Design the prototype

Design the prototype based on the agreed purposes, features, workflow, and implementation approach.

Additional step: Estimate costs

Estimate development and ongoing operating costs, including labor, cloud infrastructure, APIs, and other required services. Make an initial estimate after selecting features and refine it as implementation choices become clearer.

Status: This document captures the current concept for team discussion. Feature prioritization, feasibility, and cost estimates remain to be decided.